

The Discourse to the Kālāmas: Discernment, the Ethical Life and Fake News

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 53:41

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-awakened one.

So I'm going to do something a little bit topical. It's about fake news. I'm going to give you a book that's very good on this actually, called *The Art of Clear Thinking* by Rolf Dobelli, who's a Swiss author. But I'll come back to that.

The main discourse which tries to give us some basic ideas as to how to judge what is correct or incorrect is called the Kālāma discourse, the Kālāma Sutta. So I'm just going to go through that. Normally people use this to say that the Buddha allowed complete free thinking and it was completely up to you in a way to decide what was true or not true, and you'll see why when we go through it. But actually when you read the full discourse it's a slightly different message because it's not quite complete freedom to do what you want. You know, this postmodern thing that I do my own thing in my own time, in my own way. Everything's relative. What's true for me is true for me. It might not be true for you. Tough. Forget tradition and all that sort of stuff.

So even rationality is undermined in a way, or at least questioned. Because remember that the Enlightenment, our wonderful Enlightenment in the 18th century, people like Kant and Hobbes, produced of course eventually the document of the United Nations human rights document. But it also produced Nazism and communism. So rationality, remember, is always based on a premise. If the premise is wrong, then that's it. If the premise is right, that's good fortune. And this of course is the Buddha's own particular position, because he always talks about wrong view, and it always starts off the path, right view. So if your view is wrong, if your understanding is wrong, then the rest follows through as being unwholesome, and vice versa.

So we'll just take our time reading through this and you'll get the feel of it. "Thus have I heard." So remember this is Ānanda remembering this particular discourse.

"Once the Blessed One was wandering in the Kosala country with a large community of *bhikkhus*, and entered a town of the Kālāma people called Kesaputta. And the Kālāmas, who were inhabitants of

Kesaputta, said, 'Reverend Gotama, the monk, the son of the Sakyans, has, while wandering in Kosala country, entered Kesaputta. The good repute of the Reverend Gotama has been spread in this way: Indeed, the Blessed One is thus: consummate, fully enlightened, endowed with knowledge and practice sublime, knower of the worlds, peerless guide of tamable men, teacher of divine and human beings, enlightened, blessed. He declares this world with its gods, its Māras, its Brahmās, this generation with its ascetics and brahmins, its rulers and people, which he by himself has through direct knowledge understood and realised. He sets forth the Dhamma, good in the beginning, good in the middle, good in the end, possessed of meaning and the letter, and complete in everything. And he proclaims the holy life that is perfectly pure. Seeing such consummate ones is good indeed.'"

Now that's a... they didn't say that. That's a pat phrase that you get. Whenever the Buddha appears somewhere, that last bit always appears with him. So it's obviously an implant.

But the point is that when he gets there, they went to where the Blessed One was and arriving paid homage to him. This is a nice little aside to tell you how people behaved. So some exchanged greetings with him and after cordial small talk, sat down to one side. Some saluted him raising their joined palms and sat down to one side. Some announced their name and family and sat down to one side. And some without speaking sat down to one side. So you get this idea of people coming in very slowly, and they also had this way of going around somebody three times paying respects.

So they're all sitting there. And this is what they say: "There are some monks and brahmins, Venerable Sir, who visit Kesaputta. They expound and explain only their own doctrines, and doctrines of others they despise, revile and pull to pieces. Some other monks and brahmins too, Venerable Sir, come to Kesaputta. They also expound and explain only their own doctrines, and the doctrines of others they despise and revile and pull to pieces. Venerable sir, there is doubt, there is uncertainty in us concerning them. Which of these venerable monks and brahmins spoke the truth and which falsehood?"

So now, if the Buddha had been like one of these people that they just mentioned, these wandering ascetics, you would have expected him to say, "Well, they're all rubbish. Here's the four noble truths." But he doesn't. He answers this way. He says, "It is proper for you Kālāmas to doubt, to be uncertain. Uncertainty has arisen in you about what is doubtful. Come Kālāmas."

Now this is the statement that everybody quotes whenever you get a passage on free speech or the freedom of thought that the Buddha allowed. This is usually what they will quote: "Do not go upon what has been acquired by repeated hearing, upon tradition, upon rumour, or upon what is in a scripture, nor upon surmise, upon axiom, nor upon specious reasoning, nor upon a bias towards a notion that has been pondered over, nor upon another's seeming ability, nor upon the consideration 'this teacher is our teacher.'" So just because it's a teacher, you believe him, you see.

Now if we go through that, you'll see it covers virtually everything, although I think there's one point that might be missed. So the first four are to do with tradition.

So the first word is *anussava*, and it's in conformity with what has been heard. So remember, in those times, nothing was written down as such. It was all remembered. And that was partly the brahmins' job, to remember all the discourses, all their Vedas and stuff. So what Bhikkhu Bodhi writes is generally understood to refer to the Vedic system, which according to the brahmins had originated with the primal deity, and had been handed down orderly through successive generations. So here you've got the equivalent of things like the Bible, the Quran, the Guru Granth Sahib of the Sikhs. So he's saying, you know, don't just believe it because it has this history to it, this deep history to it, saying that this was written by God and therefore you have to believe it.

So that's one way that he says it. You've also got the similar thing with secular religions like communism and national socialism. But that's slightly different because it comes on to rationality. Anyway, so the reference here is clearly to the tradition of blind repetition, you know, you were taught this as a kid and this is what you believe. So you never question it.

The second one, *paramparā*, which is to do with legends, tradition, lineage signifying tradition in general, an unbroken succession of teachers. So you see it's very similar. So again it's referring to this way of just believing something because that's what you were taught.

The next one, number three, is just by hearsay. They're very close, these, or tradition, rumour. Source of confusion. Or by general consensus. See, that's another problem that we have. Just because a lot of people believe it, therefore it must be true. So Gandhi was supposed to have said, "Truth can be in a minority of one."

Just using this little point here for the referendum that we had, it's interesting what the respondents said to certain questions. Respondents were also asked separately whether they had enough information about what would happen in the event of a remain vote and a leave vote. 65% agreed they had enough information about what would happen in the event of a remain vote, 26% disagreed. 45% agreed that they had enough information about what would happen in the event of a leave vote, but 46% disagreed. So there's a whole load of people who are voting, feeling that they didn't have enough information to vote. Probably just went along with what was generally in the air, the feeling that was in the air, you see.

It was the same about the conduct of the referendum. Was it fair and balanced? 63% were against that and thought it was fair. 63% of people who voted didn't think it was fair and balanced. It's strange, isn't it? The main reasons why people thought the conduct of the campaigns was not fair and balanced is because they thought it was one-sided, unbalanced, biased, partial. 31% thought that. And 31% said that the information was inaccurate and misleading. Remain voters were more likely to say it was due to inaccurate and misleading information. 38% of leave voters thought the campaign was one-sided. The report really just damns the whole referendum as a democratic exercise. So it's this business of hearsay.

Chinese whispers, you know. There was a case in Sri Lanka which is, well, it's related. There was a monk who lives up in the forests in a three-sided *kuti*. So I mean, the tarantulas and snakes, they're all... And he's

very well known. I believe some other monks have joined him up there. And seemingly, I met him actually, he had gone for his normal morning alms round, and on the way back an elephant jumped out and ran over him.

Now, what they say to you is that if an elephant wants to kill you, it'll kill you. There's no problem with that. He obviously didn't want to kill him, he just wanted to run over him. But unfortunately, one of his big feet went and stood on him and really messed his hip up. And he was there all night on what would have been a path, really, and the villagers, where he would normally go for alms round, were wondering why he hadn't turned up, went looking for him, and that's when they found him and brought him to hospital. He didn't do a very good job on his hip, actually, because his leg was still up in the air somewhere.

So I met him, and this is actually what actually happened. When I got to... Now, I didn't know this. The first bit of news I got about it was I'd gone into Colombo for some reason or other and the Swedish monk there said to me, "Have you heard about the *sayadaw*?" I said, "No." He said, "It's just an amazing story. He said he was sitting under a tree meditating in posture and a she-elephant with a calf came along and when they saw him the calf became really interested and walked up to him, tried to sit in posture, fell over and broke his hip."

That's only 60 miles. It's about 60 miles. From Kandy to Colombo is about 60 miles. So it just shows you what can happen to a story.

We used to do little things like Chinese whispers when we were doing anti-racist work at the college I was at, where you'd tell an initial story of a carriage or something, and somebody stole something. And you would actually point out who actually stole it. And you would say that there were certain people in the carriage, and one of course was coloured. And you would point to somebody and say, "Well, they stole it." By the time it got round to all the whispers, it was always the coloured guy who'd committed the crime. This is in a white class, of course, mainly a white class. So you can see how prejudice, how what you want to think just keeps changing the story ever so little towards your prejudice, towards your bias. So that was the referendum.

The fourth one, the word actually means, it's much the same, collection of scriptures, what is in the scripture. So it's seeing them as infallible. So for instance, even though the study of the Bible, the exegesis of the Bible is so developed these days, they can tell you what parts of the story came from where, like the whole business of the flood, it's a Mesopotamian myth and things like that. And there are two stories of the creation melded together. I mean, you know, it's all pulled apart like that. And yet you get people who believe that it is actually the word of God and that the whole of creation happened in six days and whatnot. So you can see that this authority that people give to scripture because of its ancientness and so on and so forth.

Okay, so that means, it's telling us that whatever we read in the Buddhist scriptures, we don't just take for granted. That also refers to us as interested in the Dhamma.

The next four are concerned with thinking. So the first one is translated as logical reasoning, logical conjecture or surmise. Reflection, logic, reflection. So this is on the basis of logical reasoning.

Now, rationality, there's a lovely story, well, the story around Galileo is informative of this, because when Galileo wrote his paper, it was deemed to be heresy. They really got in for it. And Galileo had measured, I think he basically supported the works of Copernicus, I'll be hazy about all this, but when the authorities discovered this, read it, they decided it was heretical. And the reason was this, that God had created the world. And the apex of his creation, the wonder of his creation was the human being. And the idea that we should be floating around the sun rather than the sun floating around us was horrific. And not only that, you could see it. You could see it every morning. The sun was rising and falling. So there's a bit of perceptual understanding.

But the reasoning was that it was unreasonable to think that the apex of God's creation would be wandering around the sun rather than around the stars rather than them wandering around us. And of course he had to recant, you see. He had to take it back. I think later on he got it out there, but that just shows you how reasoning based on some premise, if the premise is wrong then you're messed up.

The second one is inferential reasoning. And this, you know, the Buddha wouldn't go there at all. The basis of inference. So if we take, shall we say, a Hindu position as opposed to a Buddhist position, the union, and they also have it in Christianity, the union with God, *Brahman*, or with God in the Christian tradition. When you read the mystics, it's actually a singular experience.

So to quote Meister Eckhart, the 13th century mystic, "The eye, that I see God with is the same eye that God sees me with." So in that experience, there's no duality. That's what they mean by non-dual. There's no duality. The reason why they say non, if you say one you beg the number two. So they get beyond this by saying non-dual. We have the same problem with attachment. If you read the earlier Buddhist books they'll use the word detached, to be detached. Well that sounded awful to people, you know. "I could be detached and yet love somebody." So they had to coin this new thing of non-attachment. So it's neither detached nor attached, it's non-attached. So it's something that lies above it. So you've got the same language problem with duality and oneness. So you say it's non-dual. So it's neither this nor that.

So here you've got a master telling us that there's this experience which he is saying is an experience of God, but there's no object there. So in other words, he's inferring that this must be an experience of God. And from that inference, there's a presumption that everybody's soul has this same experience. And from that, you get the concept of God with all these beings that have this union with him. You can see that that's an inference. You can't actually experience it.

So it's the same with Hinduism, shall we say. The *ātman*, when it is non-dual experience in Hinduism is to be at one with *Brahman*. So that's an inference, you see. So the Buddha wouldn't go there. So that's why there's no teaching about what relationship your *Nibbāna dhātu*, your Nibbanic element, your Buddha nature is with anybody else's. Or what relationship it has to, shall we say, something that's created it or

not created it. There's nothing at all in the Buddhist scriptures about that, you see.

So the Buddha is quite clear that all he's teaching is what can actually be experienced and he's clear that *Nibbāna* is, as far as he's concerned, the ultimate happiness. And that's it. And once you've attained that in this life, you're radically changed by it. So that's why this quote from the nun, Medhā Jyoti, I put up there. And when you die, again, the inference is that you either disappear, you just disappear into that state as an eternal state.

But even that's a little bit hazy because, as you know, the Mahāyāna say that the Buddha comes out of that called by compassion towards all beings. But it's all inference. We don't know. So he says that you have to be careful when somebody talks to you about it, when he talks, that you can distinguish between what's experiential and what's actually being inferred.

The next one, again, is really just talking about specious reasoning, silly reasoning. So it's a reflection on appearances, which refer to theories such as, it's got here as an example, the Big Bang Theory. So that is a theory. There can't be, I don't think, any absolute decision about that because it begs the question as to why it happened in the first place. So it always goes back to this original point where, okay, there was this explosion, but hey, why? Where has it come from? Because nothing comes of nothing, to quote wonderful Shakespeare. So it's that sort of reflection you have to be careful of.

There's also this business about you've thought about something, you've actually gone through the whole process, but again it says there's a bias towards a notion. And that's what we're not always aware of—our biases. These days you get the word bias being used as opposed to prejudice. A prejudice is something that you're quite aware of, but a bias is a sort of way of looking. I gave a talk a couple of weeks back on the way that we as a culture receive Buddhism through our biases unknown to us. We're not fully aware of the fact that we're always judging the Buddha's teachings, always reframing it in terms of science or in terms of the romantic movement.

The whole idea of being at one with nature—you get Buddhist writers talk about, well, eventually what we want is this beautiful oneness with everything, which is actually a romantic idea. There's nothing that I know of in the scriptures about the oneness with nature. It's always about getting your morals right and really discovering this other transcendent experience of *nibbāna*. Not that you don't have those experiences, but it's definitely not where Buddhism has got its teachings towards. If they arise, all well and good, but that's not the purpose. That would also be another transitory state, as the Romantics pointed out. You could get blissed out in nature one day, and then the next day it rained. So you can't hold it.

So you've got to be careful of these biases that we're not aware of. And how do you become aware of them? Well, that's another good question. How do you become aware of your biases? And it's through really discussing these things with people who have different views. So that was something else that comes out very clearly in, say, the American election, where on the surface of things, it looked as though Clinton had it made. But then there were all these—I mean, Facebook is especially criticized for it—that

people were really only reading their own little group, just reestablishing, cementing their views and opinions as a group and therefore weren't listening at all to anybody else. And when the election came, of course, it was all a big surprise. So you have to be careful about agreement after pondering views. Obviously it has to have an appropriate base to it.

One thing that seems to be missed in this is intuition. That sort of gut feeling. That sort of feeling of being right or being wrong. You get people saying things like "I feel" and it annoys people who say "I think," because people who say "I feel" have an intuitive grasp of it but can't often explain why, and people who say "I think" want to know why, and people who say "I think" annoy people who say "I feel" because often their thinking isn't right according to their feeling, according to the way they've intuited something.

I remember little arguments arising out of that separation at Gaia House around the coordinators, what we'd call the managers at the time. "I feel," "I think." But you can't trust your intuition either, because you don't know where you're coming from. Just because you have an intuition that something is right or wrong, it still has to be tested, you still have to question it. Your intuitions also are based upon a bias. An internal bias with which we're looking at the world.

I mean, in terms of the spiritual life, our fundamental biases are that happiness is to be found in this world, in the sensual world. That things have some sort of permanency. That I have a sense of me that is permanent, even though everything else is changing. That's the problem with the self. So these more deluded, deeper biases, delusions are actually biasing the way that we experience life, creating perhaps expectations that aren't possible.

The final one is to do with the teacher. It's just really having too much faith in the teacher and what seems probable. So, I mean, that's an interesting one because generally you have to have a certain confidence in your teacher. And it's interesting because when you, if anything happens whereby you lose confidence in the teacher, the whole thing is actually snapped.

I remember it happened to me. I had a teacher who I had a lot of admiration for and all that and et cetera, et cetera. And then he did something and just something snapped and I thought, no, this guy won't do. And I left. I went somewhere else. And it wasn't that he was evil or anything. I just lost confidence in him. And it's not that I didn't go back and stay with him and form a good relationship with him, but it was as though something had sort of snapped my faith in him, which might have been a good thing.

I mean, sometimes you do over... I don't think you can help giving your teacher an aura that they don't actually have. Because you're always looking to them for advice and whatnot. And there's always that tendency to see them as slightly more enlightened, better, more ethical, et cetera, et cetera, than they actually are. And when they trip, you think, oh, blood and sand, I'm not going to. You're probably doing it to me. I'm preparing for you to say, what the bloody hell's going on?

So it's just one of those things. You can't help it. But everybody does it to anybody who leads. I mean, that's

the whole point of a leader, isn't it? They sort of surround themselves with this charisma, which isn't something that they may have particularly developed. People have dumped it on them. I've actually seen them like that. And it's very blinding. And the Buddha wouldn't have any of that, too. There's a lovely bit just as he's dying where there's a young monk who's looking upon him with the eyes of adoration, and he sends him off into the forest to go and meditate. So it's just a wrong sort of relationship.

So he's very clear about what the relationship of a teacher and a student should be, that the student should be constantly questioning the teachers. I mean, obviously following the directions as best they can, but then never being completely taken in. You'll probably all be leaving tomorrow.

So anyway, if we now just read on. So he made this statement about what not to believe. But he doesn't leave it there. Remember, these people aren't... This is probably the first time they've seen him. They don't know him very well. They've heard this rumour, this reputation that he has, but they don't know him. So he starts right from the beginning.

He says, "What do you think, Kalamas? Does greed appear in a man for his benefit or harm?" "It's for his harm, venerable sir." "Being given to greed, being overwhelmed and vanquished mentally by greed, this man takes life, steals, commits adultery and tells lies. He prompts another to do so, to do likewise. Will that be long for his harm or ill?" "For his ill, venerable sir."

And then he goes on the same sort of process about hate. So there's greed, there's hate, and will that be long for his harm and ill? Well, yes, Venerable Sir. And what do you think of delusion? Overwhelmed by delusion, he takes life, steals, et cetera. So that's also not so very good. Are these things for good or bad? They're bad, Venerable Sir. Blameable or not blameable? Blameable, Venerable Sir. Censured or praised by the wise?

So here, you see, he's not saying you can make up your own mind about things, you can have your own thoughts and go your own way. This business of blameable and praised by the wise constantly comes up in his teaching. So you have to actually find out what somebody whom you see as more trustworthy or more advanced than yourself in terms of morals and spiritual life and to be able to take that advice. "Undertaken and observed, do these things lead to harm or ill or not? And how does it strike you?" "Undertaken and observe, these things lead to harm and ill. This is how it strikes us." "Therefore, I say"—and then it repeats that formula—"do not, just believe somebody because of this and this and that."

And then, of course, he says the opposite. So when there isn't greed, and a person does not take life, does not steal, et cetera, et cetera, will that be long for his benefit and happiness? "Yes, venerable sir." And then he does the same process. Remember, this is the oral tradition, so it's all put in a particular way so you can actually remember it. So there are phrases spoken over and over again.

So again, hate, will that be long for his benefit? No, no, definitely not. And then the same with delusion, okay? So these people don't know him, and he's giving them a way to find out whether something is

beneficial or not for them. And he's giving them something that they can relate to immediately, which is greed, hatred, aversion, and delusion.

So then, of course, and finally to sum it all up, he says, "When these things are taken, is that for good or bad? Undertaken, observed, these things lead to benefit and happiness. And this is how it strikes us." And then he repeats this. Then there's a repetition of that formula. "Don't believe anybody because of this and that."

But now, having sort of laid down a sort of moral platform by which they can decide whether something is good or bad, he then tells them how to live. So a disciple of the noble ones, Kalamas, in this way, devoid of coveting—that's the greed—devoid of ill will, undeluded, clearly comprehending and mindful, dwells having pervaded with the thought of amity, of love, one quarter, likewise the second, the third, the fourth—like we do in the evening—and so above and below and across, he dwells, he dwells having pervaded all the existence of all living beings everywhere, the entire world with the great, exalted, boundless thought of love that is free of hatred and malice.

So now he's telling them how to actually practice in his daily life. And then he goes, he says the same thing with compassion, the same thing with joy and the same thing with equanimity. So there you've got your four *brahma-vihāras*, something that you can actually develop in your ordinary daily life.

So having laid down a sort of moral platform that we should be doing what is a benefit to us and to ourselves and to others, he then gives a practice whereby you would support that sort of attitude, which is developing love, compassion, joy and peacefulness.

And he says when you get to this, he says you get these four consolations, four solaces. So when a disciple of the noble ones has such a hate-free mind, such a malice-free mind, such an undefiled mind, such a purified mind, there is one of the four consolations or solaces are to be found here. Suppose there is a hereafter. Suppose there's an afterlife. And there is a fruit, result of deeds done well or ill, then it is possible that at the dissolution of the body after death, I shall arise in the heavenly world which is possessed of the state of bliss. This is the first consolation.

Supposing there is no hereafter. So there's no afterlife and there is no fruit, no result of deeds well done or ill, yet in this world here and now free from hatred, free from malice, safe and sound and happy I keep myself. So this is the second consolation. So even if you even if you drop dead and that's the end of it at the end of life, practicing like this at least brings you a certain level of happiness in this very life.

And in the same way, or in the opposite way rather, supposing evil befall an evildoer, I, however, think of doing evil to no one. Then how can it affect me who has done no evil? So in other words, there's a sort of presumption there that if you're not committing evil, it's less likely for evil to come towards you. So obviously, if you're a sort of very angry sort of person, then you might find somebody who's actually more angry than you. And then you're stuck. This doesn't mean, of course, evil doesn't approach us, but there's a

consolation there that you won't excite somebody's hatred towards you.

Supposing evil results do not befall an evildoer, then I see myself purified in any case. So because I don't do evil and there are consequences, because I don't do evil then evil won't come to me. If there is no consequence to evil then that's fine, because I don't do evil, no consequences will come to me. So here he's arguing about fate and about free will and we'll come to that towards the end. So these are the four solaces. And, of course, he says the opposite with doing good. So we can expect that we'll have good results from a moral life.

Now, of course, at the end, they're all absolutely gobsmacked by the Buddha and they end up saying, "Marvellous, Venerable Sir, marvellous. As if, Venerable Sir, a person who were to turn face upwards what is upside down or to uncover the concealed or to point the way to one who is lost, or to carry a lamp in the darkness, thinking those who have eyes will see visible objects. So has the Dharma been set forth in many ways by the Blessed One. We, Venerable Sir, go to the Blessed One for refuge, to the Dharma for refuge, to the community for refuge. Venerable Sir, may the Blessed One regard us as lay followers who have gone for refuge for life from today."

So he obviously had a big effect. So to sum up the discourse to the Kalamas, remember that they don't know the Buddha, or they don't seem to know him, and he's not going to try and convert them, he's going to try and help them to discover for themselves what is wholesome for them and not.

So first of all, remember he asks these questions about basically the moral life. Is something wholesome or unwholesome? And then once he's done that, he then goes on to explain about greed, hatred and delusion—well, that's part of it really—and then what happens when they're not there. And then of course he says like once you've got your moral life going, then you've got to develop these four qualities, the four *brahma-vihāras*, the illimitables: love, compassion, joy and peacefulness. But you could extend that of course to any virtue.

And then of course there are the four consequences, consolations or solaces of how they're behaving. So if there is a future life they'll get the benefit of good behaviour, and even in this life. So even if there isn't a future life, then in this very life they'll get the benefit of a moral life. So that's basically the teachings of this particular discourse.

Just before the big battle where his troops were completely outnumbered by the opposition in front of Rome. He was attacking Rome. He had this dream, it seems, of a cross. So he must have been listening to the Christian preachers who were around at the time. This is the fourth century, right? So there were lots of religions in those times, as you know, or at least there was one major understanding about polytheism, and Christianity was battering its way there. And it seems as though he had a dream with this cross, some sort of cross with a cross in the middle of it. So he woke up with the presumption that this was going to win him his battle. So he had everybody paint it on their shields, and he won. And then he thought, "Well, I'm a Christian after all," and that was it. It's a weird story, how the whole of history can be changed by a

dream and the empowerment that you give to a dream.

So yes, that brings us to the end of that. And just as a side topic is, of course, the whole thing about free will. How free is the will? Well, it's not really exercised the East very much. There are, of course, people who've talked about conditioning and all that. But the West is really caught up in it. And if I'm right—you'd have to do your own little research—it all goes back really to St. Augustine. Saint Augustine argued that God created human beings to love him. Now, you can't condition somebody to love you and feel really good about it, right? You feel really good about somebody who out of their free will loves you. So he gave everybody the free will to love him or not. Which in Christian terms is really about morals, because that's what Moses brought down from the mountain. He brought down a set of rules whereby people could live peacefully together.

But it's exercised our philosophers a lot. And you get, I think Jean-Paul Sartre said something to the point that you are free to make any decision, but you're either too afraid to do it or too stuck in a rut. But you're actually free to make that decision as a conscious choice. And then you get people who are fatalists who think you've no choice at all. Similar things were happening in the Buddha's time. There were people who said that it didn't matter whether you went down the Ganges one way with great acts of love and the other way murdering and thieving and all that. Eventually it was just all conditioned and there were no consequences. It just happened.

So free will... What's been argued by Buddhist writers, or most Buddhist writers, is what they call a compatibilist position, where yes, you are conditioned, but you do have a measure of free will. If you think of the path—I mean, people talk about the spiritual path and the Buddha talks about the path and he says it's an ancient path. So now, if you go on a walk and you're walking along a path and you come to a fork or something, you tend to get out your map to make sure you're going the right way, and you consult the map and then you go off that way. If as you go along you think, "Oh, you've misread the map," then you come back to the crossroad and you go the other way. So there's a choice, you know, because of our delusion. There's a choice. The choices come up because we're deluded, because we don't actually know the path.

But that's all that is. It's not as though the Buddha was unconditioned as a human being. He still was conditioned. So we can see from Mechi Kiao that she still sees these leftover traces in the mind of greed, hatred and delusive thinking. See? So it's not as though they've gone. And she would have behaved in a conditioned way. She'd have got up in the morning, gone for her alms round, sat down, etc., etc., had talks about the Dharma with the nuns, and so on and so forth. So it's not as though you become completely... This psychophysical organism that is working in society, etc., etc., becomes unconditioned. That's not the unconditioned bit. That's always going to be conditioned.

Our job is, as the Buddha points out in the Kalama discourse, is to get those habits which are going to bring us just a natural happiness, a natural ease with life. The unconditioned is pointing to something else. It's pointing to that which doesn't belong to this order of things. But there's nothing there. The Nibbanic

experience is one which is so transcendent of this life that it's completely empty of it. So that's what he means by this *suñyatā*. It's empty of anything that we gain from this psychophysical organism. And it's that which is the unconditioned, and that's why it doesn't have any suffering. That's why it's a perfect blissful state, even though there's no emotions.

So all these words that we use are all anchored in our actual living day-to-day life. But what he's saying is that there is something which is just simply not of this order. And the process of getting there is not the process of free will, of choosing. Yes, there are choices. The main thing is discernment. It's actually looking at what we're doing and questioning everything we do to see whether it's bringing us a natural happiness in this life or unhappiness. And then to begin to start seeing things from these three vantage points of desire, impermanence, not-self. And slowly but surely there's an awakening. Right? That's the best word of all. A slow awakening of something in us which doesn't belong to this phenomenal world.

And that's it folks. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. That they have not caused even greater confusion. And that by your devotion to the spiritual life you will relieve yourself of all suffering sooner rather than later.

Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.